



A WOMAN AS A WOMAN!
In the film *Shakespeare in Love*, Gwyneth Paltrow plays a woman who disguises herself as a boy because she wants to act. After watching her play Juliet in *Romeo and Juliet*, an outraged royal official leaps onto the stage shouting "That woman is a woman!"

The boy player

ONLY MEN COULD ACT ON THE English stage in Shakespeare's time, so women's roles were performed by boys. Although these actors were called boy players, they probably played females until they were in their 20s. Shakespeare sometimes had fun by making the boy players act the parts of women disguised as men. Rosalind, the heroine of *As You Like It*, pretends to be a man called Ganymede. In disguise as Ganymede, Rosalind, who is in love with Orlando, offers to help him practice his wooing techniques by pretending to be the object of his affections – herself. So the boy playing Rosalind had to act as a woman, pretending to be a man, playing at being a woman!



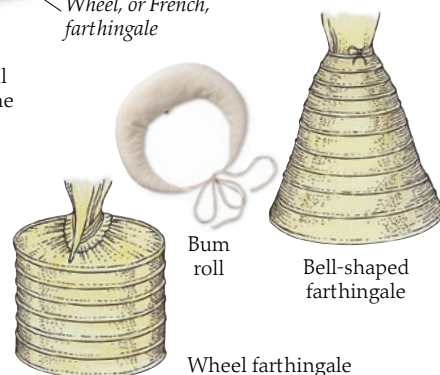
1 FIRST THINGS FIRST
In the tiring room of the playhouse, a boy player is getting ready to go on stage. He is playing Rosalind, the heroine of *As You Like It*. He begins his transformation by putting on a petticoat.

2 HELPING HANDS
Next, the boy player puts on a tight upper garment called a bodice. He needs some help from the tireman, who laces up the back.

3 OUTSTANDING!
The boy steps into a hooped farthingale, which the tireman will fasten around his waist to make the skirt of the dress stand out.

4 SKIRT OVER HOOP
The tireman helps the boy into a beautiful, embroidered skirt, which will show through a gap at the front of the dress.

FASHIONABLE FIGURES
The women's fashion at the time for exaggerated hips and rear ends was achieved with a farthingale – a series of hoops made of whalebone, wood, or wire – or a padded belt called a bum roll. This fashion was a great help to boy players trying to look convincingly female.



The real thing

A boy player needed the help of the company's tireman to get ready for his performance. To play the part of a noblewoman, he would dress in clothes that might once have been worn by a real noblewoman. Once a boy was wearing his farthingale, dress, makeup, and wig, the audience found him convincing as a female. English travelers to other European countries were amazed to see real women acting there.

*"If I were a woman I
would kiss as many of you
as had beards that
pleased me."*

WILLIAM SHAKESPEARE
Rosalind in *As You Like It*